Week 3 Notes: R&B, Country, and Early Soul

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Setting the stage for rock 'n' roll — from the Week 3.1, 3.2 and 3.3 slides plus the lecture recording. The Week 3.1 sections are reconstructed from slides only.

Big Picture

The week's organizing question is how an industry comes together to market music in new ways. Genre here is not only a description of sound — it is a category built by labels, radio formats, and trade charts to sort audiences.

Two ideas run through both lectures:

- **Genre as industry construction.** Labels like "hillbilly," "race records," and later "country and western" were marketing categories first. They say as much about who the industry thought was listening as about the music.
- **Crossover.** One song succeeding in more than one market — across genres and radio formats (early Taylor Swift charting country *and* pop), or across racially defined categories (Louis Armstrong, Ray Charles).

This sets up rock 'n' roll next week: a large new youth audience arrives, and listeners outside that audience need the industry to make sense of the music for them.

Postwar Context (Week 3.1)

The week opens with **why** R&B and country both rise after the war.

World War II

- **Increase in production**
- **Military training in the Southern U.S.** — moving people, and music, into the South and back out again
- **Improved financial situation for many citizens** — an audience with money to spend
- **The Great Migration** continuing (see Week 2)

Recording and broadcasting

- **New financial opportunities**
- **Mass culture / mass media**

A pause in production — war rationing. Records could not be made freely:

- **Shellac** was imported from India, cut off by the Pacific blockade
- **Vinylite** was diverted to waterproofing and war material

This is a good example of the Week 1 "technology" theme working *against* the industry: the physical substance a record is made of becomes a war material, and the whole business pauses. It also helps explain why the postwar years feel like a surge — demand had been dammed up.

Radio and the Rise of the DJ

The radio DJ: "an individual who was **jockeying** or **riding** a record toward success." The etymology is the job description — the DJ is not a neutral conduit but someone actively pushing particular records.

Jack L. Cooper (1888–1970)

- The **first African American DJ**
- One of the first to play records at all — gospel and jazz

Worth noting against the Week 2 material: at a moment when the industry sorted music by the performer's race, radio created a role where a Black broadcaster chose what a national-scale audience heard.

Alan Freed appears here with the *Moon Dog House* programme on WJW — nightly 11:15 pm–1:00 am, advertised with "Blues / Rhythm / Jazz." He returns in Week 4 as the DJ who popularised the term "rock and roll" and bridged segregated audiences.

Also pictured: country radio programmes like the Briarhoppers on WBT, sponsored by a patent-medicine tonic. Sponsorship is how this all gets paid for — keep it in mind alongside WSM and the Grand Ole Opry below.

Blues Structure

Emphasis on lyrics.

12-bar musical cycles, AAB:

- **Two melodic/rhythmic patterns** (A, A)
- **A resolving third line** (B)

Often in 4/4 — 1-2-3-4 = one bar of music.

The chord grid from the slide (I, IV, V in Roman numerals):

Section	Bars	Chords
A	1–4	I – I – I – I
A	5–8	IV – IV – I – I
B	9–12	V – IV – I – V

Worked example — "Sweet Home Chicago":

- **A:** "Oh baby don't you want to go" (4 bars)
- **A:** "Oh baby don't you want to go" (4 bars)
- **B:** "Back to the land of California; to my sweet home Chicago" (4 bars)

Learn this well — the 12-bar blues is the frame under Count Basie's "One O'Clock Jump," Chuck Berry's "Maybellene," and a great deal of early rock 'n' roll. Being able to count the A-A-B as it goes past is the single most useful listening skill in the course.

Three Periods of Blues

Period	Centre	Character
1. 1920s – 1940s	Mississippi Delta	Acoustic, rural; work songs and call-and-response
2. 1940s – 1950s	Chicago and Memphis	Electrified; greater focus on singers and lyrics
3. 1960s – 1970s	Popular culture at large	Rock bands covering blues songs

The movement down this table is the Great Migration told as music: rural South → northern industrial city → international rock canon.

Period 1: the Delta (1920s–40s)

- **Mississippi Delta**
- **Work songs**
- **Call-and-response**

- **Guitar — available, cheap**

That last point is the materialist explanation, and it is easy to miss. The guitar becomes the blues instrument partly because it is portable and affordable — not because of anything about its sound. Compare the piano's role in Tin Pan Alley, which depended on a middle-class household budget.

Robert Johnson (1911–1938, Mississippi)

- The **myth of selling his soul at the crossroads** — note the slides call it a myth; it is a story *about* the blues that later rock culture found irresistible
- **"Sweet Home Chicago" (1936/1937)** — the AAB example above, and a song whose title points north along the migration route

Period 2: Electrified, Urban, Renamed (1940s–50s)

Chicago and Memphis. "Electrified." Greater focus on singers and lyrics. Muddy Waters, B.B. King.

Muddy Waters (1913–1983, Mississippi)

- "Father" of modern **Chicago blues**
- Arrives in **Chicago, 1943** — the migration in one biography
- **Electrified / amplification**
- **Delta Blues → R 'n' R**

"Hoochie Coochie Man" (1954)

- Written by **Willie Dixon**
- A Chicago Blues classic/standard
- **Full backing band**
- **"Stop time," call and response** — the same two devices you hear in Ray Charles's "I Got a Woman," also 1954

T-Bone Walker (1910–1975, Texas)

- An influence on **B.B. King**
- Master showman: **"did the splits without missing a beat"** — the photographs show him playing the guitar behind his head and in the splits
- **"Stormy Monday" (1947)**: "About the average guy…you can sing it anywhere, if you can sing"

T-Bone Walker matters for Week 4: the lecture names him alongside Sister Rosetta Tharpe as the electrified-blues precedent behind Chuck Berry's guitar showmanship.

The 1949 renaming. *Billboard* adopts **"Rhythm and Blues"** to refer to **all Black secular popular music** — urban blues, Chicago blues, doo-wop, small-band jazz, and rhythm and blues. Brackett's definition: **"a blues-based music that used jazz elements but was designed to meet the dancing and partying needs of an urban, African American audience."**

Note the symmetry: 1949 is the same year Billboard settles on "Country and Western." Both race-coded categories get their modern names in the same moment — the industry tidying its filing system on both sides of the colour line at once.

Period 3: Blues and Popular Culture (1960s–70s)

Rock bands covering blues songs. The case on the slides:

Version	Artist	Year
"Cross Road Blues"	Robert Johnson	1936
"Crossroads"	Cream	1966

Thirty years, a retitling, and a British rock band. Run it against the Week 2 appropriation framework — movement across a power difference, with the marketing stripping the origin — and against the Week 4 pattern of the Beatles covering Little Richard. The blues does not simply "influence" rock; specific songs are carried across by specific bands, and the carrying is what makes the canon.

This also closes the loop with Robert Johnson's crossroads myth: the legend travels with the song, and it is the 1960s rock audience that makes it famous.

Country: Background (Week 3.2)

Before "country" settled as a name, the same music circulated under several labels: **mountain music**, **bluegrass**, **cowboy music**, and **hillbilly music**. Little Richard later called it "the white man's blues" — a reminder that the genre line was racial as much as musical.

Instrumentation

- Fiddle, banjo, guitar — especially in early Appalachian country

- 1938 onward: electrified instruments, notably the electrified steel guitar, begin to transform the genre

Lyrical content

- "Transforms marriage, divorce, love and loss into a narrative of catastrophic tragedy"
- Often focused on everyday, "simple" situations

Honky-Tonk and Hank Williams

The 1930s bring new subgenres and new performance contexts. Honky-tonk comes out of the **rural South**, named after the honky tonks — the bars that featured the style — and produced a run of stars through the 1930s and 40s.

The honky-tonk sound

- Full rhythm section, steel guitar, fiddle
- Nasal vocals, becoming sharper over time
- Focus on working-class life
- Small, economical band formation — the same logic that later suits early Elvis (a three-piece) and Chicago blues groups

Hank Williams (1923–1953, Alabama)

- Member of the Grand Ole Opry
- Struggles with alcoholism and health problems; dies around the time of the track studied
- "Your Cheatin' Heart" (1952/53) — symbolic of his status as a lonely figure
- A "bracket reader": constantly touring and playing, but timing his travel to land in Nashville for the Saturday night Opry broadcast

In the lecture, the sound is described as darker and clangy — gritty in a way that matches the venue it is named for.

Western Swing and the First Crossovers

Western Swing is fiddle-led string band dance music fused with big band swing — which makes sense, since the 1930s are also the swing era. Alongside bass and fiddle it adds **drums, amplified guitars, horns, and pianos**, plus studio effects and vocal approaches borrowed from Western cinema.

"New San Antonio Rose" — two versions

Version	Year	What to hear
Bob Wills and His Texas Playboys	1938/1940	Large ensemble, horns, big swinging sound; still poppy enough for radio
Bing Crosby	1941	Pop crooner treatment — the swing-band elements stripped back, voice foregrounded

Same song, two markets. That is the clearest demonstration of crossover in the lecture: the song is immensely popular precisely because it exists in versions aimed at different formats.

Why Western Swing declined

- The rock 'n' roll boom favoured smaller bands and a different sense of backbeat and danceability
- After the war, big bands cost more to run in dance venues
- Radio airplay stayed strong, but touring the sound became difficult

The decline is gradual, not sudden — by 1949 Billboard's "western" category still reflects this music's popularity.

Charts: How the Industry Renamed the Genre

The chart names are the clearest evidence that genre is an industry category being worked out in real time — roughly a decade of relabelling.

Year	Billboard category
1939	"Hillbilly" chart begins tracking country's popularity
1945	"American Folk"
1949	"Country and Western"

In 1939, a country record charted as hillbilly unless it had crossover appeal — in which case it also appeared on another chart.

Nashville, WSM, and the Grand Ole Opry

Nashville becomes the hub: a major phonograph recording centre with songwriters and labels concentrated in one city. But the lecture's emphasis is that **radio**, not records alone, carried the music nationally. As Brackett puts it, "What brought this homely music out of the back roads and into great popularity nationally — and now internationally — was radio in general and in particular station WSM."

The formula to remember: **Opry + radio (WSM → NBC national)**.

Year	Development
1925	Grand Ole Opry begins as a country music stage show in Nashville, broadcast on WSM (Saturday night tradition)
1939	Picked up by NBC Radio — heard nationally
1943	Broadcast from the Ryman Auditorium
1974	Moves to the Grand Ole Opry House

The WSM logo on the microphone in the lecture slide is the visual shorthand for the whole system: a live performance wired directly into a national radio audience. Today the Opry is a larger entertainment complex outside Nashville, streaming performances online — a more polished, professional operation built on the same live-broadcast idea.

The Nashville Sound

Starting in the late 1950s (roughly 1957/58), the Nashville Sound smooths country's rougher edges to reach the pop market. Country was the genre that changed *least* across the war years — so this is the significant shift, and it comes from the industry side.

What changes:

- Honky-tonk elements replaced with elements of pop music
- The nasal, yodelling vocal qualities are lessened or removed entirely — Patsy Cline, who built her career partly on the yodel, is pushed toward a poppier delivery
- Poppy background singers added for radio appeal — which cuts against country's built-in idea of authenticity
- Repeated use of studio musicians: the **Nashville A-Team**, the **Anita Kerr Quartet**

Patsy Cline, "I Fall to Pieces" (1961)

- Charts on both country and pop — a crossover hit
- Backing vocals by the **Jordanaires**
- Around two and a half minutes: built for radio

The tension. Crossover binds new audiences together, but genre purists can read it as compromising the essence of the genre — the Taylor Swift problem again. Cline herself was not especially invested in the pop charts; the direction came from studios and labels pushing artists.

Session musicians and in-house bands become central well beyond Nashville — think of the polished 1960s records by the Beach Boys, the Byrds, and folk rock generally.

Sister Rosetta Tharpe (Week 3.3)

1915–1973, Arkansas. Gospel and pop-gospel: spirituality + rhythm (R&B, R&R).

Tharpe plays **electrified guitar as a lead instrument** in a recognisably rock 'n' roll way, years before the figures usually credited with it. In performance she moves with the guitar in front of an audience — the same stage presence audiences would later receive with enthusiasm from Chuck Berry and Elvis.

"Strange Things Happening Every Day" (1944/45)

- Clearly a gospel song, but with a full band behind it
- Lands on the rhythm-and-blues-based race record series as well as in gospel
- The first big crossover hit between the gospel and race record markets

Why she is less well known. Rock gets coded over time as an authentic, masculine genre, because its stars through the 1960s were largely young white men from the US and the UK. Labels and the marketing machine wrote a number of figures out — and her categorisation as a gospel artist, plus being a woman playing this music, kept her contribution off the standard story.

The copyright point (important for Ray Charles). Traditional spiritual songs are widely known, sung by congregations, and generally **without copyright**. That makes them open to adaptation and new lyrics, and recordable without paying royalties. Early soul is built on exactly this openness.

Ray Charles

Ray Charles Robinson, 1930–2004, Georgia. Multi-talented musician: pianist, singer, saxophonist, arranger. From a very poor background in the American South to national success — like Jimi Hendrix later, moving north to find new audiences (Seattle, 1948, where he has radio hits in northern cities).

1953–55 breakthrough — the formula in three parts:

1. Gospel music
2. Secular lyrics
3. Rhythm and blues instrumentation

"Thinly veiled adaptations of gospel songs"

- "I've Got a Woman" (1954) — from "It Must Be Jesus" by The Southern Tones
- "This Little Girl of Mine" (1955)
- "Hallelujah, I Love Her So" (1956)

"I Got a Woman" keeps the source song's shape almost intact while changing the theme entirely; it was later sampled in Kanye West's "Gold Digger," which shows how this era of soul became raw material for hip hop.

Vocal and instrumental style

- "Raspy, exuberant tones"
- "Whoops, cries, bent notes, shouts"
- "Call-and-response patterns" with horns or backup singers (the Raelettes)
- Gospel-style piano

The deeper point: gospel singers use voice and body to express power and energy — saying more than the lyrics can on their own. Charles grew up inside that tradition rather than borrowing it from outside.

"What'd I Say" (1959)

- Move to Atlantic Records (1954)
- Grew out of improvisation during a live set in 1958
- Crystallises **soul** as a genre; Charles becomes the "High Priest of Soul"
- Controversial — banned by some stations
- About seven minutes long

Criticism and the soul/rock distinction. Charles was attacked for "taking church songs and making people dance to 'em in bars and nightclubs" — dance tied to youth and sex, performed in venues that were emphatically not churches. In his own words: "Rock 'n' roll was also music that the teenagers were able to play themselves…my music is more serious, filled with more despair than anything you'd associate with rock 'n' roll." And: "Since I couldn't see people dancing, the dance crazes passed me by…I wrote rhythms which moved me and figured they'd also make other folk move."

There is something to that distinction: soul gets mapped onto the civil rights movement and carries a political orientation, while early rock 'n' roll largely did not. The two overlap much more in the 1960s.

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Crossover	A song succeeding in more than one market — across genres, radio formats, or racially defined categories
Honky-tonk	1930s rural Southern country style named for its venues; full rhythm section, steel guitar, fiddle, nasal vocals, working-class subjects
Western Swing	Fiddle-led string band dance music fused with big band swing; drums, amplified guitars, horns, pianos
Hillbilly chart	Billboard's 1939 category for country, renamed "American Folk" (1945), then "Country and Western" (1949)
Nashville Sound	Late-1950s production style replacing honky-tonk elements with pop ones: smoother vocals, background singers, studio musicians
Studio / session musicians	In-house players used repeatedly to produce polished records (Nashville A-Team, Anita Kerr Quartet, Jordanaires)
Race records	Industry category for music marketed to Black audiences, alongside rhythm and blues

Term	Definition
Pop-gospel	Gospel combined with rhythm, opening a path into R&B and rock 'n' roll
Soul	Genre crystallising around 1959 from gospel vocal style + secular lyrics + R&B instrumentation; later tied to the civil rights movement
Call and response	Alternation between a lead voice and horns or backup singers, carried over from gospel
Stop-time	A brief break in the accompaniment that exposes the voice — heard in "I Got a Woman"
12-bar blues (AAB)	Twelve-bar cycle: two repeated lines (A, A) and a resolving third (B); chords I–IV–V
Delta blues	1920s–40s Mississippi style: acoustic guitar, work songs, call-and-response
Chicago blues	1940s–50s electrified, urban blues with a full backing band (Muddy Waters)
Rhythm and Blues	Billboard's 1949 category for all Black secular popular music, replacing "race"
Disc jockey	"An individual who was jockeying or riding a record toward success"
Shellac rationing	Wartime shortage of record-pressing material (shellac from India; vinylite diverted to war use)

Listening List

Track	Artist	Year	Listen for
"Your Cheatin' Heart"	Hank Williams	1952/53	Dark, clangy honky-tonk sound; nasal vocal; small band
"New San Antonio Rose"	Bob Wills and His Texas Playboys	1938/1940	Large ensemble, horns, swing-band texture behind a crooner vocal

Track	Artist	Year	Listen for
"New San Antonio Rose"	Bing Crosby	1941	Same song stripped to pop crooning — the crossover version
"I Fall to Pieces"	Patsy Cline	1961	Faint Jordanaires backing vocals; polished, ~2.5 minutes, radio-ready
"Strange Things Happening Every Day"	Sister Rosetta Tharpe	1944/45	Gospel vocal over a full band; guitar taking over as lead instrument
"It Must Be Jesus"	The Southern Tones	—	The source: nearly the same music as "I Got a Woman"
"I Got a Woman"	Ray Charles	1954	Gospel delivery, decidedly un-gospel lyrics; the stop-time moment
"What'd I Say"	Ray Charles	1959	Call and response, improvisation, the arrival of soul — listen before Monday's class
"Sweet Home Chicago"	Robert Johnson	1936/37	Count the AAB: two repeated lines, then the resolving third; acoustic Delta texture
"Stormy Monday"	T-Bone Walker	1947	Electrified lead guitar before rock 'n' roll; the ordinary-life lyric
"Hoochie Coochie Man"	Muddy Waters	1954	Stop-time and call and response; full band — compare with "I Got a Woman" the same year
"Cross Road Blues" / "Crossroads"	Robert Johnson / Cream	1936 / 1966	Thirty years and a retitling — the appropriation argument in one pair

The instructor flagged "What'd I Say" specifically: Monday's class opens with it, and at roughly seven minutes it may not fit in full, so listen ahead.

Self-Check

- [ ] Define crossover in two senses — by format and by racial category — with one example of each from this week
- [ ] Name three things the Nashville Sound changed about country records, and say why each was controversial
- [ ] Trace the Billboard chart names 1939 → 1945 → 1949 and explain what the renaming reveals about genre
- [ ] Explain the role of WSM and the Grand Ole Opry in making country a national genre
- [ ] Give two musical reasons and two economic reasons Western Swing declined
- [ ] Explain why traditional spiritual songs were so useful to Ray Charles — musically *and* legally
- [ ] Describe four features of Ray Charles's gospel-derived vocal style
- [ ] Summarise Charles's own argument for why soul differs from rock 'n' roll, and one limitation of that argument
- [ ] Say why Sister Rosetta Tharpe is under-credited, using the two reasons given in lecture

Course Logistics from the Lecture

Assignment (submission button now live)

- Personal pronouns are fine — write from your own perspective and bring a personal voice in
- Structure: introduce songs, artists, and key comparisons in the first paragraph; then one to three body paragraphs on examples and details; start a new paragraph whenever you move into a new thought or mode of analysis
- The examples and description are the most important part
- Deadline 11:59 pm Friday; the syllabus late policy applies automatically if you need extra time — no email required
- Check the upload actually went through, as a PDF or Word file; empty submissions do happen

Coming next

- Monday opens with "What'd I Say"

- Then two longer units: early rock 'n' roll influences, and a longer one on Elvis (early Elvis is a three-piece before horns are added)
- Labels to watch: Sun (Memphis) and Chess (Chicago); artists: Chuck Berry, Elvis
- Theme: rock's ties to youth culture, and how the press sensationalised it as a threat to orderly, proper youth

Readings

David Brackett, *The Pop, Rock, and Soul Reader: Histories and Debates* (Oxford, 2020) is the source behind the quoted material in this week's slides. Every "(Brackett)" attribution is a primary document reprinted there with its own introduction — so the reader gives you the full text and context for what the slides show in one line. From this week:

Quote in these notes	Topic
"What brought this homely music out of the back roads and into great popularity nationally — and now internationally — was radio in general and in particular station WSM…"	Nashville, WSM, the Opry
"Rock 'n' roll was also music that the teenagers were able to play themselves…my music is more serious, filled with more despair…"	Ray Charles on the soul / rock 'n' roll distinction
"Since I couldn't see people dancing, the dance crazes passed me by…"	Ray Charles on writing rhythm
"taking church songs and making people dance to 'em in bars and nightclubs"	The criticism of Charles
"raspy, exuberant tones"; "whoops, cries, bent notes, shouts"; "call-and-response patterns"	Charles's vocal style

Simon Frith, "The Industrialization of Music" (in *The Popular Music Studies Reader*, Routledge 2000, pp. 231–238) is the theoretical frame under this entire week. The argument that genre is an industry category — hillbilly → American Folk → Country and Western, race records, the Nashville Sound as a production strategy — is Frith's claim that popular music is shaped by the industry that produces and sells it, not merely distributed by it. Read it before the midterm; it converts this week's facts into an argument.

Tara Brabazon, *Popular Music: Topics, Trends & Trajectories* (Sage, 2012) is general background rather than a source for anything specific here.

Page references are not given above because the slides cite Brackett without them — look the quotes up by artist section in the reader.